



The Journal for Cultural and Religious Theory (JCRT)

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Preacher

Mike Grimshaw

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Preacher, or the Death of God in Pictures

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We philosophise on the end of lots of things, but it is here that they actually come to an end.”¹ Jean Baudrillard in his episodic ‘postcard’ treatise on hyperreal America, (the theorist as traveller), posits a vision of the USA as simultaneously both a paradoxical ‘realised utopia’² and “the *only remaining primitive society*”³, a dystopian utopia, a society best understood from the sacrificial expanse of the desert horizon. Baudrillard’s aphorism on America as the land of ‘last things’ finds pop-culture realisation in the pages of Garth Ennis’ *Preacher*, a 66-issue, graphic novel. For if Nietzsche proclaimed the Death of God in the 1880s and the ‘Death of God’ theologians debated the merits of this claim; if *Time* asked the question in 1966, then readers of *Preacher* comic actually see it happen. God dies. God is shot. God is killed. And you understand why.

> At its core it stood for a distrust of any kind of authority; a romanticised belief in working class culture (street credibility); the worth of rebellion for its own sake; and the fetishisation of

This nihilistic punk aesthetic is an important undercurrent to *Preacher* not only in Jesse’s defeating as those believing in a God who profess love but display indifference. Here Aresface

> The illustrations are not really illustrations of what’s going on. The narration isn’t real.

To read a comic is therefore to engage in looking beyond what is being presented to the fuller enlightenment society rather fantastical and ‘artificial’. This has been noted in an interview

> Of course, being in the comic world allows you to throw in casually, “We have this reanimat

The comic can therefore present what is, in a modernist, secular world, often viewed as unpress world for the reader to engage with and within.

Notes

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¹Jean Baudrillard, *America* trans. C. Turner (London/New York; Verso 1988/1993)p.98.

²ibid., p.77.

³ibid., p.5.

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Updated 07/28/21.
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